WEEK 11 · LECTURE L2 · UNIT IV

# HR as Digital Change Agent

The roles HR must hold, capability, mandate and credibility, the reskilling of HR itself, and the politics of making transformation happen.

R K Singh · Senior Professor, Department of Commerce · Delhi School of Economics, University of Delhi

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AFTER THIS LECTURE YOU SHOULD BE ABLE TO

# What this lecture prepares you for

1. Use Ulrich’s four roles to show which HR roles shrink and which must grow under digital transformation.
2. Explain what a change agent needs (capability, mandate, credibility) and why HR faces reskilling more than replacement.
3. Map stakeholders with the power and interest grid and stakeholder salience, and use force field analysis and Pfeffer on power.
4. Plan for the long arc of change: Kotter’s errors and the J curve.

**ONE SOURCE**

The same theories as the in class lecture and the course hub, without the simulation data used in class. Course outcome: CLO 5.

COMMIT BEFORE THEORY

# Commit to an answer first

## Automation absorbs most of an HR team’s transaction work. What is the biggest risk to the team?

**A**

Immediate redundancy for everyone

**B**

Being left without the skills and standing for the roles that remain, such as change agent and employee champion

**C**

No risk: HR always survives

**D**

That employees will stop needing HR

**EXAM LENS**

The answer is B: a reskilling case, not a redundancy case.

ULRICH (1997)

# Four roles for HR

Strategic focus ↑

| | |
|---|---|
| **Strategic partner**<br>Aligning HR and business strategy | **Change agent**<br>Managing transformation and change |
| **Administrative expert**<br>Efficient HR processes: automated most by digital HR | **Employee champion**<br>Listening and responding to employees |

Processes → People

EXAM LENS

Automation absorbs the administrative expert. If HR does not move toward change agent, the function shrinks; if it moves without keeping the employee champion role, it loses the trust change depends on. Ulrich later recast these as competencies, such as credible activist and change champion.

WHAT A CHANGE AGENT NEEDS

# Capability, mandate and credibility

### Capability

Data literacy, technology judgment, change skill and consulting. HR often has the last, not the first two; it must reskill itself first.

### Mandate

A sponsor and formal decision rights from the CEO and Board across functions. Without it, HR proposes and others decide.

### Credibility

Earned by early, visible wins that matter to line managers (Kotter’s short term wins); a failed launch spends it.

COURSE FRAMING

A change agent without all three is a messenger, not an agent.

SCULLY-RUSS AND TORRACO (2020), PP. 83 TO 89

# HR development in a changing world of work

**Skills**

Continuous learning built into daily work, not classes bound to place and time.

**Voice**

Workers shaping the rules of their work; HR beyond its role as the employer’s functional agent, shaping how technology is designed.

**Identity**

Shifting work changes how people build identities at work (p. 68); those moving between jobs and gigs keep realigning who they are (p. 74).

EXAM LENS

HR’s own exposure: HR officer roles typically carry moderate automation risk (routine transactions automate, judgment does not). Experienced HR staff are at greater risk of being left without the skills the new model needs than of being replaced. The change agent must manage its own reskilling, or it leads a change it cannot join.

# Mapping stakeholders

| | Low interest | High interest |
|---|---|---|
| High power | Keep satisfied | Manage closely: the guiding coalition |
| Low power | Monitor | Keep informed |

| Stakeholder | Cares about | Can block |
|---|---|---|
| CFO | Cost, return, risk | Budget |
| Line managers | Staffing, output, time | Daily adoption |
| IT | Security, integration, workload | Technical delivery |
| Frontline staff | Ease, language, fairness | Use, through workarounds |
| Gig workers | Earnings, voice | The network |

**EXAM LENS**

Build the coalition from the high power, high interest corner; do not ignore the quiet high power, low interest group, who can stop the change; give voice to high interest, low power groups. A coalition of HR alone lacks position power over operations.

Power and interest grid commonly attributed to Mendelow (1981).

THEORY IN DEPTH · MITCHELL, AGLE AND WOOD (1997)

# Which stakeholders get attention

### The core idea

Stakeholder salience depends on three attributes: power, legitimacy and urgency.

### How it works

Those with all three are definitive stakeholders; those with only legitimacy are often ignored.

### Limits and critique

Salience is perceived by managers, so it can be misjudged.

**IN PRACTICE**

Gig workers have legitimacy and urgency but little power; a fair strategy gives them weight anyway.

**EXAM LENS**

Classify each stakeholder by the three attributes; this structures a strong analysis.

THEORY IN DEPTH · LEWIN (1951)

# Force field analysis

### The core idea

Any situation is held in balance by driving forces and restraining forces.

### How it works

Change happens more easily by reducing restraining forces than by pushing harder.

### Limits and critique

A simplification: forces interact and change over time.

**IN PRACTICE**

Removing a restraint (no regional language interface) may achieve more than another push (a mandate to use the app).

**EXAM LENS**

Pair with Kotter: Kotter adds driving forces; Lewin reminds you to remove restraining ones.

THEORY IN DEPTH · KOTTER (1995)

# Eight errors that make transformations fail

### The core idea

From studying change efforts, Kotter listed common errors, starting with not establishing enough urgency.

### How it works

Others include no powerful guiding coalition, under communicating the vision, declaring victory too soon, and not anchoring change in the culture.

### Limits and critique

Evidence is drawn from Kotter’s consulting experience rather than systematic study.

**IN PRACTICE**

Declaring victory at go live is the most common error in HR technology programs.

**EXAM LENS**

Note the evidence limitation; it shows critical engagement with a famous model.

THEORY IN DEPTH · PFEFFER (1992)

# Getting things done needs power

### The core idea

In organizations, change requires understanding and using power, not only good ideas.

### How it works

Map interests and influence, build alliances, and time moves for when support is strongest.

### Limits and critique

Power can be used for narrow ends; the theory is descriptive, not a license.

**IN PRACTICE**

A sound analytics case fails without allies among line managers and in finance.

**EXAM LENS**

Use Pfeffer to argue that HR’s technical expertise is insufficient without political capability.

THE LONG ARC OF CHANGE

# Launch, dip, persistence, anchoring

**Launch**

Energy, attention and early adopters.

**The dip**

Costs show first; benefits lag (the J curve: Brynjolfsson, Rock and Syverson, 2021).

**Persistence**

Short term wins keep the coalition together.

**Anchoring**

New ways embedded in roles, rules and culture (Kotter, 1996).

EXAM LENS

Benefits arrive after the intangible work, and only if leaders hold course. A strategy must budget for the dip and name the leading indicators that show progress before outcomes move.

APPLY

# An HR team asked to lead its own disruption

**Teaching case (Course framing)**

A Lucknow based insurer automates claims and HR transactions. Its 60 person HR team, many with over fifteen years of service, is told to “lead the digital transformation”. The project is sponsored by the CFO; the IT head controls the budget; the employees’ union has not been consulted.

**Work it through**

1. Which of Ulrich’s roles shrinks, and which must grow?
2. Which of capability, mandate and credibility is weakest?
3. How should reskilling address identity, not only skills?
4. Place the CFO, IT head and union on the power and interest grid.

COMMON CONFUSIONS

# Tempting readings, and better ones

| A tempting reading | A better reading |
| --- | --- |
| Automation makes HR redundant | It shrinks the administrative role and raises demand for change agency and employee advocacy |
| Change agency is a communication task | It needs capability, mandate and credibility |
| Uninterested stakeholders can be ignored | High power, low interest stakeholders can stop a change |
| Go live is success | Declaring victory too soon is a classic error |

COMPARE AND EVALUATE

# Six lenses on HR as change agent

| Lens | Use it to | Watch out for |
|---|---|---|
| Ulrich (1997) | Show which roles shrink and grow | Roles later recast as competencies |
| Capability, mandate, credibility | Test readiness to lead | Course framing * |
| Mitchell, Agle and Wood (1997) | Classify stakeholders | Salience is perceived |
| Lewin (1951) | Remove restraining forces | Forces interact |
| Kotter (1995) | Avoid classic errors | Consulting based evidence |
| Pfeffer (1992) | Build political capability | Power for narrow ends |

* The course’s own framing.

PRACTICE FOR THE END TERM EXAMINATION

# Questions to rehearse

Using Ulrich’s four roles, Scully-Russ and Torraco, and stakeholder mapping, explain how an Indian public sector bank’s HR function should lead its own digital transformation. **20 marks**

**A strong answer:** uses Ulrich’s axes to show which roles shrink and grow; applies skills, voice and identity to reskilling HR; maps stakeholders and builds a coalition; plans for the dip and anchoring, with a limit.

Using stakeholder salience, force field analysis and Pfeffer, analyze the politics of an HR technology transformation. **20 marks**

**A strong answer:** classifies stakeholders; identifies driving and restraining forces; proposes coalition building; notes ethical limits of power.

List Kotter’s errors in transformation and evaluate the evidence behind them. **10 marks**

**A strong answer:** names the errors and the consulting based evidence limitation.

CARRY THESE INTO THE EXAMINATION

# Four things to remember

1. **HR must reskill itself before it can lead others.**
   A reskilling case, not a redundancy case.

2. **Capability, mandate and credibility, all three.**
   Otherwise a messenger, not an agent.

3. **Map stakeholders by power, interest, legitimacy and urgency.**
   And remove restraining forces.

4. **Budget for the dip; do not declare victory early.**
   Anchor change in roles and culture.

SET READINGS · FROM THE LESSON PLAN

# Read for this week

- Westerman et al. (2014), leadership and strategy chapters.
- Scully-Russ, E., & Torraco, R. J. (2020), pp. 84 to 85 and 88 to 89.

**NOTE**

The other works named in this lecture are theory sources for reference, not set readings.

THEORY SOURCES · FOR REFERENCE

# Sources for this lecture


- Brynjolfsson, E., Rock, D., & Syverson, C. (2021). The productivity J curve. *American Economic Journal: Macroeconomics, 13*(1), 333 to 372. https://doi.org/10.1257/mac.20180386
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- Mendelow, A. (1981). Environmental scanning: The impact of the stakeholder concept. *Proceedings of the Second International Conference on Information Systems*.
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- Ulrich, D. (1997). *Human resource champions*. Harvard Business School Press.